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TODAY AT A GLANCE

- Bikaner border review: Rajasthan shares 1,037 km of Indo-Pakistan Border — longest among all states
- SARTHAK-PDS: Cabinet approves umbrella scheme integrating food grain transport assistance with SMART PDS automation
- Hydrogen Fuel Cell Train: India's first indigenous HFC trainset approved for Jind-Sonipat section
- NHA 2022-23: India's Government Health Expenditure rose to 48% [VERIFY] of Total Health Expenditure

#1 Current Affairs — Rajasthan › Border Security › Indo-Pakistan Border & Rajasthan Border Districts

WHY IN NEWS

Union Home Minister chaired a high-level border security review meeting in Bikaner to assess security issues along the Indo-Pakistan Border districts of Rajasthan.

KEY FACTS FOR RPSC

- Rajasthan shares the **longest stretch of Indo-Pakistan Border** among all Indian states — approximately **1,037 km**, passing through districts of Ganganagar, Bikaner, Jaisalmer, and Barmer
- The border is guarded by the **Border Security Force (BSF)**, which operates under the Ministry of Home Affairs; Rajasthan sector falls under BSF's **Jaisalmer and Bikaner Frontier** [VERIFY] headquarters
- **Bikaner** is both a border district and the divisional headquarters for border security coordination in western Rajasthan; it hosts critical BSF infrastructure and the **Suratgarh Military Station**
- The **Border Area Development Programme (BADP)** is the key central scheme for infrastructure development in border districts of Rajasthan — funded 100% by the Centre under Ministry of Home Affairs
- **Rajasthan angle:** Four border districts — **Sri Ganganagar, Bikaner, Jaisalmer, Barmer** — are covered under BADP; Jaisalmer district alone has the largest geographic border stretch with Pakistan

Memory Hook: **G-B-J-B** (Ganganagar–Bikaner–Jaisalmer–Barmer) = Rajasthan's four Pakistan-border districts, north to south

#2 Current Affairs — National › Indian Economy › Food Security & PDS Modernization

WHY IN NEWS

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs approved **SARTHAK-PDS** as an umbrella scheme integrating food grain transport assistance with automation of the Public Distribution System.

KEY FACTS FOR RPSC

- **SARTHAK-PDS** full form: **S**cheme for **A**ssistance in **R**ation **T**ransport and **H**andling with **A**utomation in **K**ey PDS operations — nodal ministry is **Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution**
- The umbrella scheme subsumes two components: **(i) Food Grain Transport Assistance** (freight subsidy for movement from FCI depots to fair price shops) and **(ii) SMART PDS** (technology-driven automation including end-to-end digitisation, beneficiary identification via Aadhaar)
- **SMART PDS** (Supply-chain Management and Reforms with Technology in PDS) [VERIFY] aims at real-time tracking of food grain movement, elimination of ghost beneficiaries, and cashless transactions at fair price shops
- The scheme operates within the framework of the **National Food Security Act (NFSA), 2013**, which entitles up to **75% rural** and **50% urban** population to subsidised food grains at **₹3/kg (rice), ₹2/kg (wheat), ₹1/kg (coarse grains)**

PYQ VAULT

[2024] Q44. Consider the following statements regarding 'National Food Security Act' (NFSA) in India:

A. It was enacted on July 5, 2013. [VERIFY] B. Around 50 crore persons have been covered. C. It legally entitles up to 75% rural and 50% urban population to subsidised food grains.

(a) Both B and C (b) Both A and B (c) Both A and C (d) A, B and C

Answer: (c) Both A and C

■ **SARTHAK-PDS** operates under **NFSA 2013** — the 75%/50% entitlement is directly tested here

#3 Science & Technology › Green Technology › Hydrogen Fuel Cell Train

WHY IN NEWS

Indian Railways approved India's first indigenous Hydrogen Fuel Cell-based trainset for operation on the Jind-Sonipat section of Northern Railway.

KEY FACTS FOR RPSC

- India's first **Hydrogen Fuel Cell (HFC) Train** is a **10-car trainset** [VERIFY] approved for the **Jind-Sonipat** section under **Northern Railway** zone; it is indigenously developed

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- A hydrogen fuel cell generates electricity through an **electrochemical reaction** between hydrogen and oxygen — the only emission is **water vapour**, making it a zero-direct-emission technology
- The train is developed under the **National Hydrogen Mission (NHM)**, launched in **2021**, which aims to make India a global hub for green hydrogen production and export; nodal ministry is **Ministry of New and Renewable Energy**
- Key distinction: unlike battery-electric trains (which store energy) or overhead electric trains (which need electrified tracks), HFC trains carry **onboard hydrogen tanks** and require no overhead electrification — suitable for non-electrified routes
- India's existing push in this domain: **KABIL (Khanij Bidesh India Ltd.)** secures critical minerals for battery technology; separately, **RDSO (Research Designs and Standards Organisation)** in Lucknow is the technical body overseeing railway rolling stock standards including this HFC project

Memory Hook: HFC train = **H**■**O** out, **CO**■ out — zero emission, zero overhead wire

#4 Current Affairs — National › Indian Economy › Health Expenditure & Human Development

WHY IN NEWS

The Union Health Ministry released the **National Health Accounts (NHA) Estimates for India 2022-23**, the tenth such report, showing improvement in government health spending.

KEY FACTS FOR RPSC

- **NHA (National Health Accounts)** estimates are prepared by the **National Health Accounts Technical Secretariat (NHATS)** housed within the **National Health Systems Resource Centre (NHSRC)**, under the **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare**
- Key indicator: **Government Health Expenditure (GHE)** as a share of **Total Health Expenditure (THE)** — NHA 2022-23 shows GHE rising, indicating reduced out-of-pocket burden; India's policy target (National Health Policy **2017**) is to raise public health spending to **2.5% of GDP**
- **Out-of-Pocket Expenditure (OOPE)** — money spent directly by households on health — is a critical poverty-driver; declining OOPE share in THE is the key reform metric tracked by NHA reports
- NHA follows the **System of Health Accounts (SHA) 2011** framework developed by **WHO, OECD, and Eurostat** — this ensures international comparability of India's health spending data; the **2022-23 report is the 10th edition** [VERIFY] in this series

PYQ VAULT

[2021] Q86. Which of the following is responsible for implementation of "Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana"?

(a) National Health Authority (b) World Health Organisation (c) Niti Aayog (d) IRDAI

Answer: (a) National Health Authority

■ NHA estimates and AB-PMJAY both operate under the Ministry of Health — connecting health governance with health financing data